



BERGEN COUNTY OF NEW JERSEY
VALLEY BROOK GOLF COURSE
15 Rivervale Rd. River Vale, NJ 07675



2026 MASTER PLAN

May 15, 2026



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Robert McNeil, ASGCA
The Northeast Golf Company
118 Beauchamp Drive
Saunderstown, RI 02874



A HISTORY OF VALLEY BROOK

BERGEN COUNTY • NEW JERSEY

PREPARED BY
THE NORTHEAST GOLF COMPANY

Valley Brook Golf Course sits on a gently rolling parcel of land at 15 Rivervale Road in River Vale, Bergen County, New Jersey, bounded on its western edge by Pascack Brook. The property carries six decades of golf history, played on the same ground under four different names, through multiple changes in ownership and shifts between public and private operation, a complete redesign, and ultimately a transition back to public stewardship.

PARK VALE COUNTRY CLUB, 1963 – 1973

The course was conceived and built by John Handweg, Sr. and his son, John Handweg, Jr. The elder Handweg was already a fixture in the region's golf community. Born in Old Tappan, he had been a River Vale resident for more than five decades and had built several of the area's best-known courses, including River Vale Country Club and Edgewood Country Club, as well as Camelot Country Club in Spring Valley, New York. His son John Jr., a golf champion during his undergraduate years at Dartmouth, had joined his father in the family business.

In the spring of 1963, the Handwegs were preparing two new courses for simultaneous opening: Knob Hill, near Freehold, and Park Vale Country Club, in River Vale. A photograph published on May 12, 1963 showed father and son together on the new property, checking the location of a sand trap on their newest golf course. Two weeks later, a brief notice in the local paper announced the opening:

“GOLFERS — Handweg’s Park Vale Country Club is opening for play on Memorial Day.”

The course operated as Park Vale for roughly the next decade, with newspaper records of play through the early 1970s, including a July 1972 hole-in-one by Fred Boerum of Oakland on the 155-yard 12th hole. John Handweg, Sr. died at his home on Rivervale Road on December 20, 1969, leaving the course in his son's hands and within the broader Handweg family.

PASCACK VALLEY GOLF AND COUNTRY CLUB, 1973 – 1982

Sometime between 1972 and 1974, the course changed hands and was renamed Pascack Valley Golf and Country Club. By April 1974, a new owner was speaking publicly about plans to revitalize the property, pledging to make it a meaningful test for experienced and beginner golfers alike. The course operated under the Pascack Valley name for roughly the next eight years.

PASCACK BROOK GOLF AND COUNTRY CLUB, 1982 – 1999

In April 1982, the course changed ownership for the third time in its 19-year history. With the new ownership came a new name. An April 25, 1982 article reported the change directly:

“Pascack Valley Golf and Country Club, one of Bergen County’s seven public golf courses, changed owners last week for the third time in its 19 year history. It also changed names, and is called Pascack Brook Golf and Country Club.”

Within weeks, advertisements heralded the course as under new management with major improvements underway. However, the Pascack Brook era lasted nearly two decades, and by most accounts the course's reputation declined during that span. By the late 1990s it had become, in the words of head professional Don Stenberg, “a horror show ... a bad layout that was poorly maintained and managed.” Local golfers joked that the course was a “dog track,” that someone had simply “spray-painted a parking lot green.” A “hard-hat area” in the middle of the property exposed players to stray balls from neighboring holes. The fairways were described as “mostly crabgrass.” The course had become, in Stenberg's summary, “just a golf mill,” moving rounds through but offering little of the experience the property could support.



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A HISTORY – CONTINUED

BERGEN COUNTY • NEW JERSEY

THE REDESIGN, 1999 – 2001

In the late 1990s the property was acquired by United Properties Group. United Properties Group commissioned a comprehensive redesign and renovation, retaining Atlanta-based golf course architect, and later ASGCA member, Bill Boswell to lead the work.

The redesign was substantial. Holes 1 through 6 and 10 through 15 were retained in approximately their original positions, but the remaining holes were rerouted to accommodate a new 270-yard practice range. The clubhouse was reimagined in a Cape Cod style, with a tin roof, a new banquet facility, and an expanded pro shop. A 9,000-square-foot putting green was installed at the clubhouse, alongside additional practice greens and bunkers. A new pond was excavated in front of the clubhouse, between the new 9th and 18th greens; the 9th hole was rebuilt as a 164-yard par 3 playing over the new water. Tees and greens were rebuilt throughout the course, fairways were converted to bent grass, four hundred fifty new trees were planted, and a new irrigation system was installed across roughly 95 percent of the playing surface. The reworked course played to 6,150 yards from the back tees, at a par of 70, one shot lower than the layout it replaced.

A contemporary newspaper account from May 15, 2000, by Bergen Record golf writer Kevin Czerwinski, captured the work mid-flight: the course was “halfway through a major reconstruction and face lift,” and the result, the writer predicted, would be “nothing short of spectacular.” Don Stenberg, then in his third season as head professional, was thrilled at what was emerging. Yaz Consalvo, the longtime teaching professional who had been associated with the property since its opening in 1963, was continuing to teach at Emerson while the work was completed, whereupon he returned to the course he knew and loved.

VALLEY BROOK GOLF COURSE, 2001 – PRESENT

With the redesign substantially complete, the course was formally renamed Valley Brook Golf Club. A promotional advertisement from the period — “Discover a Classic... Discover Valley Brook Golf Club” — billed the property as “Northern New Jersey’s Finest New Golf Course” and invited golfers to be among the first to play it. The “Classic” framing acknowledged the property’s nearly four decades of history, while the “New” language announced its arrival as a genuinely different golf course.

The course continued under United Properties Group’s ownership for several years following the reopening. In 2006, Bergen County acquired the property from United Properties, adding Valley Brook Golf Course to its portfolio of public courses serving residents of the county. The course has operated as part of the Bergen County system ever since, alongside Darlington, Orchard Hills, Overpeck, Rockleigh, and Soldier Hill.



The Northeast Golf Company first engaged with Valley Brook in 2012, when Robert McNeil, ASGCA, led a renovation project on the course. The present Master Plan continues that relationship, providing a long-term framework for the next chapter in the course’s evolution. Sixty years after the Handwergs walked the property laying out the course, Valley Brook remains what it has always tried to be: an accessible, well-considered public golf course on a quiet, rolling piece of Bergen County land, set along the banks of Pascack Brook.

This Master Plan is offered as the next chapter in that history: a framework for strengthening the aesthetic, agronomic, and strategic qualities of the course, and for increasing the enjoyment of all who visit Valley Brook.



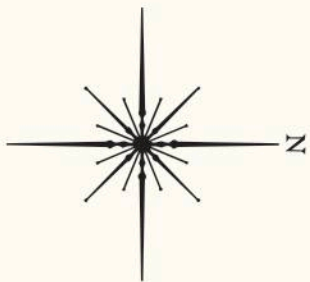
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VALLEY BROOK GOLF COURSE

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OVERALL PLAN



COURSE YARDAGE

6,230 • 5,700 • 4,610



not to scale



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Valley Brook Golf Course

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INTRODUCTION

The Master Plan that follows is the product of an extended study of Valley Brook Golf Course – its routing, its agronomy, its infrastructure, and the experience it offers the golfers of Bergen County. It is presented hole by hole, with the overall plan on the preceding page as a point of reference, so that each recommendation can be read in the context of the whole.

Valley Brook today is a fundamentally sound golf course on a fine piece of ground. The bones of the 1999–2001 Bill Boswell redesign remain intact, the routing flows well, and the property continues to offer the variety of holes and shot values that a public course of this caliber should provide. The recommendations in this plan are a coordinated program of refinements including tree management to restore airflow and turf health, bunker work to renew the strategic interest and visual character of the course, tee adjustments to reintroduce yardage flexibility, and targeted short-game and circulation improvements at greens and tees throughout the property.

One set of conditions on the property warrants particular attention. Hole 13 sits on the low ground along the western edge of the course, where the property meets Pascack Brook, and has come under increasing pressure from the brook itself. During heavy rainfall, the brook overtops its banks and floods the adjacent playing corridors, leaving this hole unplayable in the immediate aftermath of a storm and slow to recover once the water recedes. Compounding the flooding, ongoing erosion along the brook is steadily cutting into the bank, narrowing the playing corridor and threatening the long-term integrity of the hole as it sits today. Addressing the flooding and bank erosion in this corridor is a foundational element of the plan: until the water and the bank are stabilized, the agronomic and aesthetic improvements proposed cannot fully take hold. The hole-by-hole pages that follow identify the specific interventions recommended on Hole 13, which should be read alongside the broader program of refinements across the rest of the course.

Each of the eighteen hole plans that follows identifies these recommendations on the drawing itself, keyed to a brief set of notes. The recommendations vary in scope and in priority: some are modest, agronomically driven moves that can be undertaken in the next maintenance season; others are larger capital improvements best phased across multiple years. Taken together, they describe a course that is healthier, more visually coherent, more strategically engaging, and better positioned to serve Bergen County for the decades ahead.

https://thenortheastgolfcompany.com/Projects/Valley_Brook/index.html

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PROGRAM SUMMARY

The recommendations developed across the eighteen hole pages that follow are not eighteen independent projects. They are one coordinated program of work, organized into six categories that share a common rationale: restoring the agronomic health, strategic interest, and visual character of a course whose bones remain fundamentally sound. The categories are summarized below and detailed on the ensuing hole pages.

CATEGORY	SCOPE OF WORK
<u>Tree Management</u>	Removal of approximately 130-150 trees across the course to restore airflow, turf health, and playing corridors. Targeted planting of fescue framing for definition and separation between holes.
<u>Bunker Renovation</u>	Rebuild and enhance fairway and greenside bunkering across the course, updating styling and strategic function. New bunkers added at Holes 14 and 16.
<u>Tee Adjustments</u>	Strip, level, and expand existing tees to recover surface area; construct new mid and forward tees on selected holes to restore yardage flexibility lost to wear and grow-in.
<u>Short-Game Areas</u>	Develop low-cut pitch areas around greens to add variety and shot-making interest, particularly behind and beside greens currently bounded by rough.
<u>Cart Path & Circulation</u>	Reroute and reconstruct cart paths to widen playing corridors, eliminate awkward crossings, and improve flow through tee complexes and greens.
<u>Hole 13 – Flood Resilience</u>	Raise fairway and green above flood elevation; install subsurface drainage and force-main evacuation system; place targeted rip-rap at active scour points along Pascack Brook.

The program spans a range of scopes and capital scales, from modest, agronomically driven moves that can be undertaken in routine maintenance seasons to larger capital improvements appropriate for phased implementation over multiple years. Detailed scheduling, sequencing, and cost estimates will be developed in coordination with Bergen County as the plan moves toward implementation.



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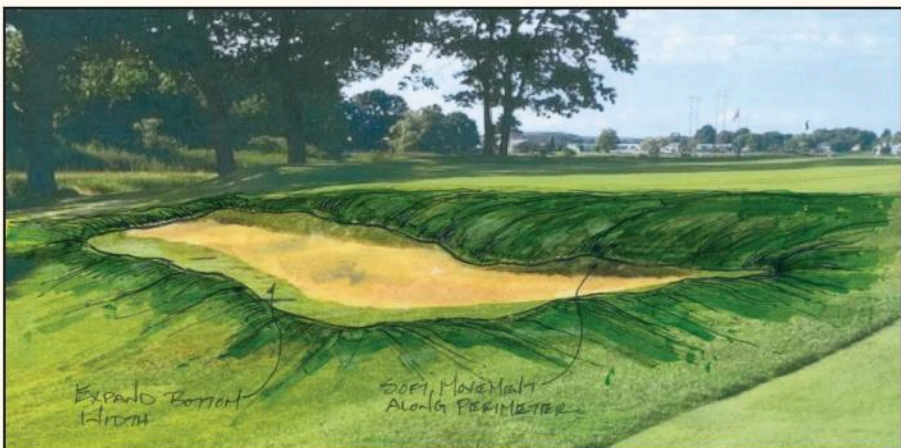
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DESIGN “DICTIONARY”

The hole pages that follow refer repeatedly to a set of design elements: bunkering, fescue framing, pitch areas, tree management, and tee complexes. These five elements form the consistent design vocabulary of the plan, applied in varying combinations across all eighteen holes. The spread below describes some of these elements, their intent, and the visual character proposed for Valley Brook.

BUNKERING

The proposed bunker character at Valley Brook is defined by long, natural lines and soft shouldering. Bunkers are shaped to follow the natural movement of the surrounding ground rather than imposed as discrete geometric forms, with edges that flow into the contour of the fairway or green surround rather than sitting against it. The shouldering is held low and softened to avoid the steep faces that complicate maintenance and shorten the life of a bunker. The result is a bunker style that is visually impactful from the tee and the approach, while remaining maintainable on a public-course budget over the long term. Bunker positioning across the course is reviewed for strategic relevance, and where existing bunkers no longer serve a clear strategic purpose, they are consolidated or removed rather than rebuilt.



Kernwood CC



Essex County CC

FESCUE FRAMING

Fescue framing refers to areas of lower-input, naturalized fescue grasses established at the edges of playing corridors and between adjacent holes. With a lower maintenance cost than mown rough, it visually defines hole edges, separates corridors, and introduces a softer, more textural character to the property. At Valley Brook, fescue framing is intended to work in concert with tree management, establishing the edges of holes through grass rather than canopy.



Milton Hoosic Club



Met Links



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DESIGN “DICTIONARY” – CONTINUED

PITCH AREAS

Pitch areas are closely-mown grass surrounds extending beyond the putting green, maintained at fairway height or slightly above. A ball missing the green rolls into a pitch area rather than collecting in deep rough, presenting the golfer with a range of recovery options (bump-and-run, lofted pitch, or putt) rather than a single forced response. At Valley Brook, pitch areas are proposed at most green complexes to reintroduce strategic interest and shot-making variety to approach play, and in several locations are designed as continuous strands connecting adjacent holes, creating a visually coherent short-game character across the property.



Cedar Hill CC



Met Links

TREE MANAGEMENT

Tree management refers to the selective removal of trees that compromise turf health, restrict airflow, narrow strategic playing corridors, or block sightlines that define a hole’s character. The program is approached as a course-health and architectural exercise, not a clearing exercise. Every tree identified for removal is identified for a specific reason and reviewed in coordination with Bergen County. Healthy trees that frame holes, anchor corners, or contribute to the character of the property are retained. Where appropriate, removed trees are offset by the establishment of fescue framing along hole edges, so that the definition and enclosure historically provided by tree canopy is preserved through a combination of grass and selectively retained trees.



Cedar Hill CC, Hole 2 BEFORE tree management



...AFTER tree management



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HOLE 1

330 • 310 • 235



NOTES

- A: Rebuilt four tees as two large tee surfaces to gain yardage flexibility.
- B: Remove 6 cedars behind tee to improve airflow.
- C: Expand cart path circulation at the tee.
- D: Remove all trees on the inside of the path (except large tree at 100 yards) to open playing corridor.
- E: Rebuild/enhance bunkering.
- F: Remove 4 trees behind green to open airflow. Develop fescue framing between 1 green and 2 tee.
- G: Develop pitch area to the left of the green.



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HOLE 2

495 • 470 • 415

NOTES

A: Remove 6 trees* inside the cart path to open playing corridor.

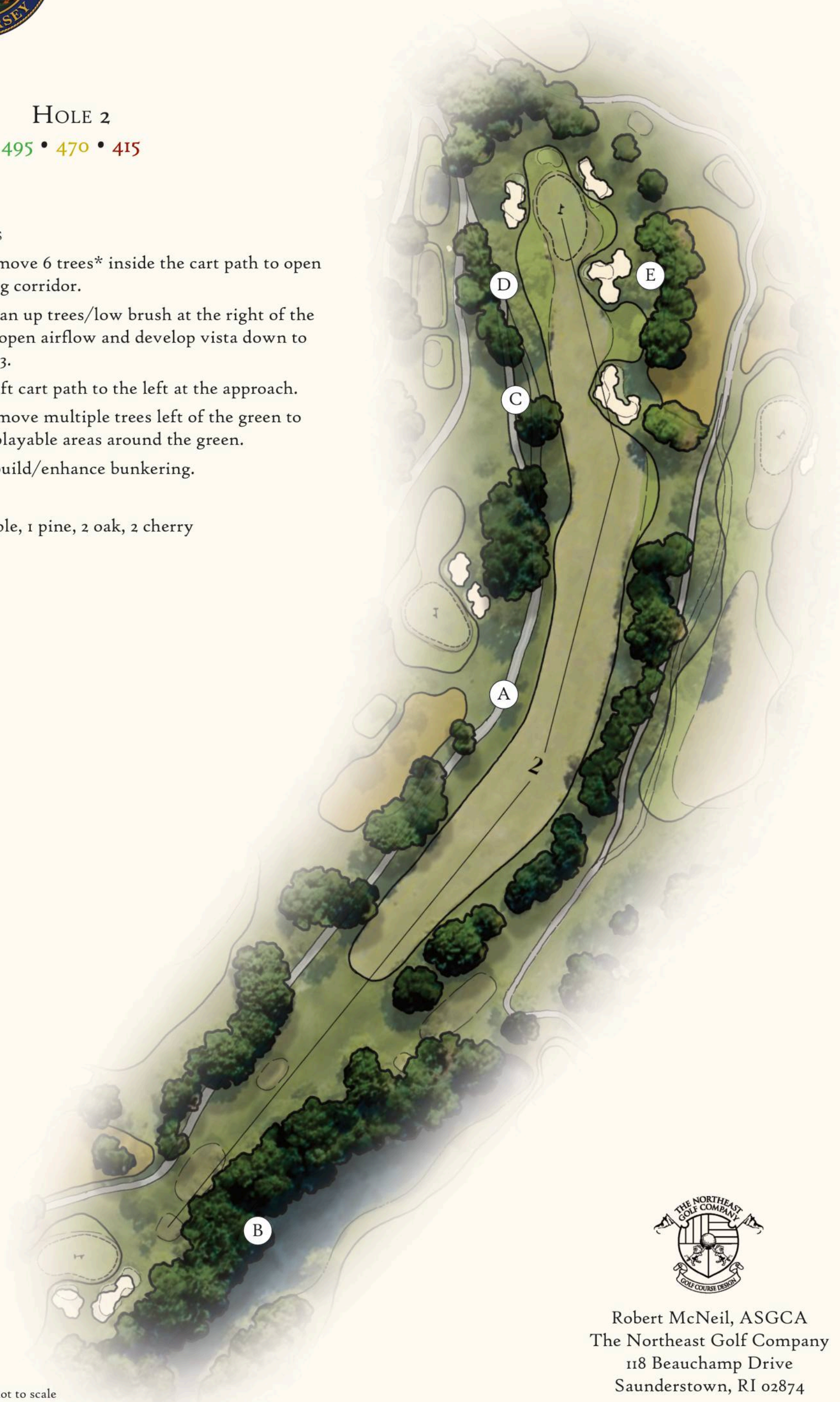
B: Clean up trees/low brush at the right of the tee to open airflow and develop vista down to Hole 13.

C: Shift cart path to the left at the approach.

D: Remove multiple trees left of the green to open playable areas around the green.

E: Rebuild/enhance bunkering.

*1 maple, 1 pine, 2 oak, 2 cherry



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HOLE 3

195 • 150 • 105

NOTES

A: Expand tees to maximize surface area and flexibility.

B: Rebuild/enhance bunker styling and function.

C: Develop pitch areas around the right and back of the green.

D: Remove 2 trees* around the green.

*1 left and 1 behind green



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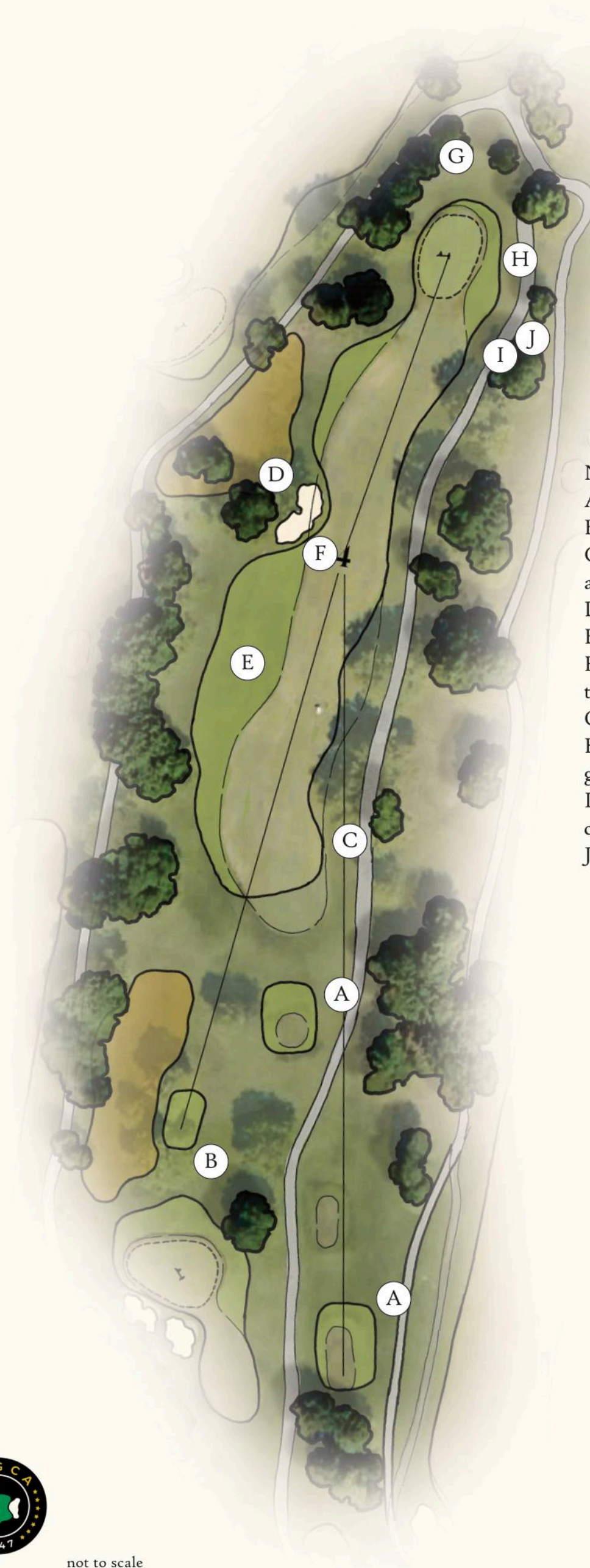


VALLEY BROOK GOLF COURSE

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HOLE 4

395 • 370 • 265



NOTES

- A: Strip/level/expand back and forward tees.
- B: Create new mid tee behind third green.
- C: Remove first two trees and 3 trees at the approach inside the cart path.
- D: Remove oak left of the fairway.
- E: Expand fairway left.
- F: Add strategic/directional fairway bunkering at the left corner.
- G: Remove 2 oaks and 3 maples behind the green.
- H: Develop low cut pitch areas all around the green to add variety.
- I: Fill low areas and/or add drainage to improve conditions between cart paths at green.
- J: Cart path repairs right of the green.



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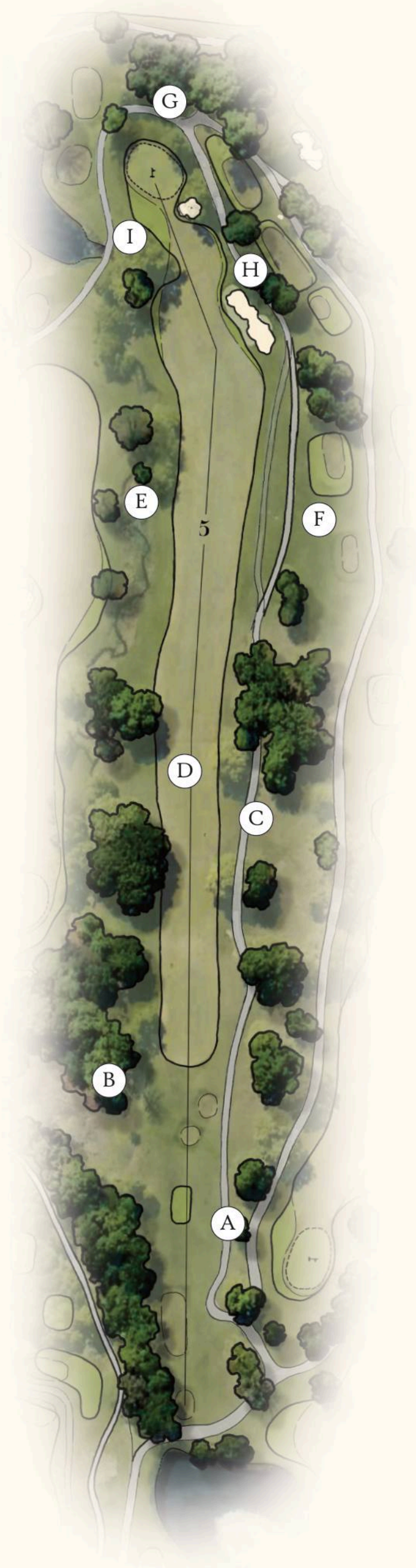


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HOLE 5

580 • 550 • 435



NOTES

- A: Add middle tee at 480 yards.
- B: Remove failing tree at the start of the fairway.
- C: Remove 4 trees along the edge of the fairway to open playing corridor.
- D: Add drainage at the first landing area.
- E: Remove 4 trees along creek at 150 yards.
- F: Shift cart path near Hole 4 tee and widen approach to improve angle of play.
- G: Remove 6 trees surrounding the green.
- H: Rebuild/enhance bunkering.
- I: Rebuild hollows into left slope.



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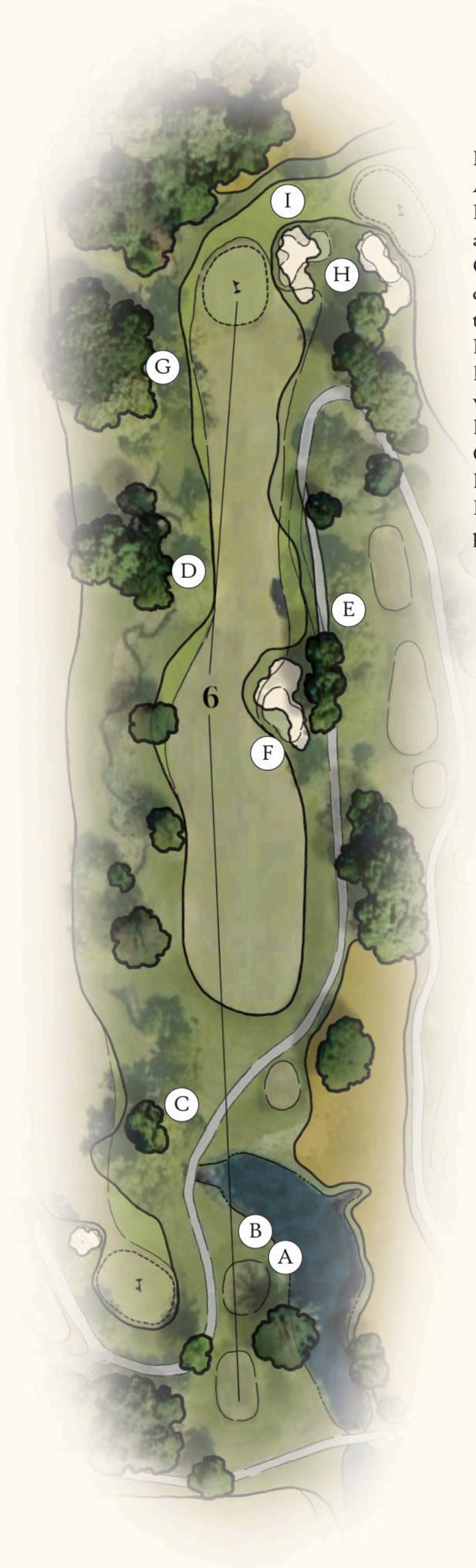


VALLEY BROOK GOLF COURSE

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HOLE 6

385 • 360 • 280



NOTES

- A: Rebuild/level middle tee.
- B: Reconstruct wall (structural/stabilize) at 6th tee.
- C: Remove 5 trees at left past the bridge to open playing corridor and air circulation for turf health.
- D: Remove 3 trees at left side of approach.
- E: Remove 2 trees at right pinch point to widen playing corridor and shift path right.
- F: Rebuild/enhance fairway bunkering.
- G: Remove 4 trees short left of the green.
- H: Rebuild/enhance greenside bunkering.
- I: Connect 6 and 8 green with short grass pitch area connection.



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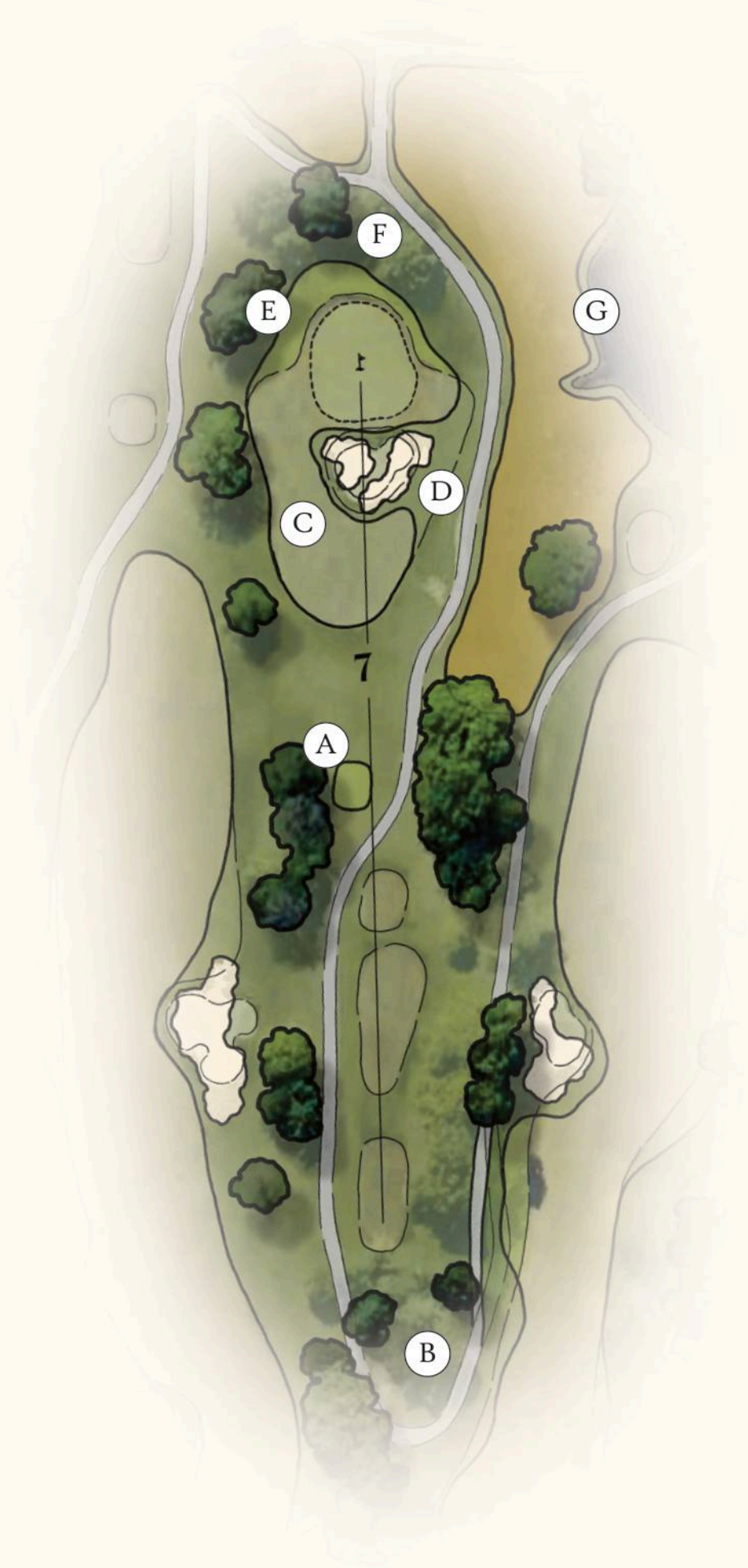
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HOLE 7

225 • 180 • 110

NOTES

- A: Add forward tee to add flexibility.
- B: Remove 3 pines behind tees to improve turf conditions.
- C: Recontour fairway around bunkers to shift away from cart path.
- D: Rebuild/enhance greenside bunkering.
- E: Develop pitch area behind the green for added shot-making.
- F: Remove 4+ pines behind the green to open airflow. Add fescue framing.
- G: Clean all areas along pond edge at holes 7 and 8.



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HOLE 8

420 • 390 • 320



- NOTES
- A: Rebuild/enhance fairway and greenside bunkering.
 - B: Adjust fairway mowing lines slightly to add visual movement to the hole.
 - C: Develop pitch area at right and behind green, tied to Hole 6 surrounds.
 - D: Remove tree long and left of the green.



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HOLE 9

175 • 145 • 90

NOTES

- A: Construct new tee complex within wooded area to the left of current tees.
- B: Utilize existing tee material to build new tee complex.
- C: Remove two oaks in front of existing tees.
- D: Rebuild/enhance greenside bunkering.
- E: Shift cart path to the left to open new line of play.



OTHER NOTES

The existing tees on Hole 9 pose a safety risk with the proximity of Hole 18. Repositioning the tees in the wooded area to the left of the existing cart path both mitigates this risk, as well as opens the 18th hole for better playability.



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HOLE 10

320 • 280 • 230

NOTES

A: Remove all cedars at the tees of holes 10 and 1.

B: Expand mid and forward tees for added surface and length flexibility.

C: Expand forward tee/construct new tee at 230 yards.

D: Paint/general cleanup around all buildings to right.

E: Remove all trees (13) inside cart path.

F: Reroute cart path to the right to eliminate crossing in front of the green.

G: Expand fairway/pitch areas short and long of the green.

H: Rebuild/enhance greenside bunkering.



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HOLE 11

315 • 290 • 260



NOTES

- A: Remove existing left cart path/use right-most path.
- B: Expand fairway in conjunction with cart path removal.
- C: Cut down/manage cattails to establish visibility from rear tees.
- D: Remove 2 trees inside cart path at 100 yards.
- E: Establish fescue framing behind green for backdrop and separation.
- F: Remove 2 pines inside cart path to right of green and back right of green.
- G: Rebuild/enhance greenside and approach bunkering, including new bunker back/left.
- H: Remove stumps at left of approach.
- I: Expand pitch area around green.



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HOLE 12

200 • 160 • 120

NOTES

- A: Clear a row of trees to the right to improve airflow.
- B: Level/expand middle tee.
- C: Cart path repairs.
- D: Rebuild/enhance bunkering with new back left bunker.
- E: Green surface repair at back left.
- F: Restore green surrounds/add subsurface drainage.



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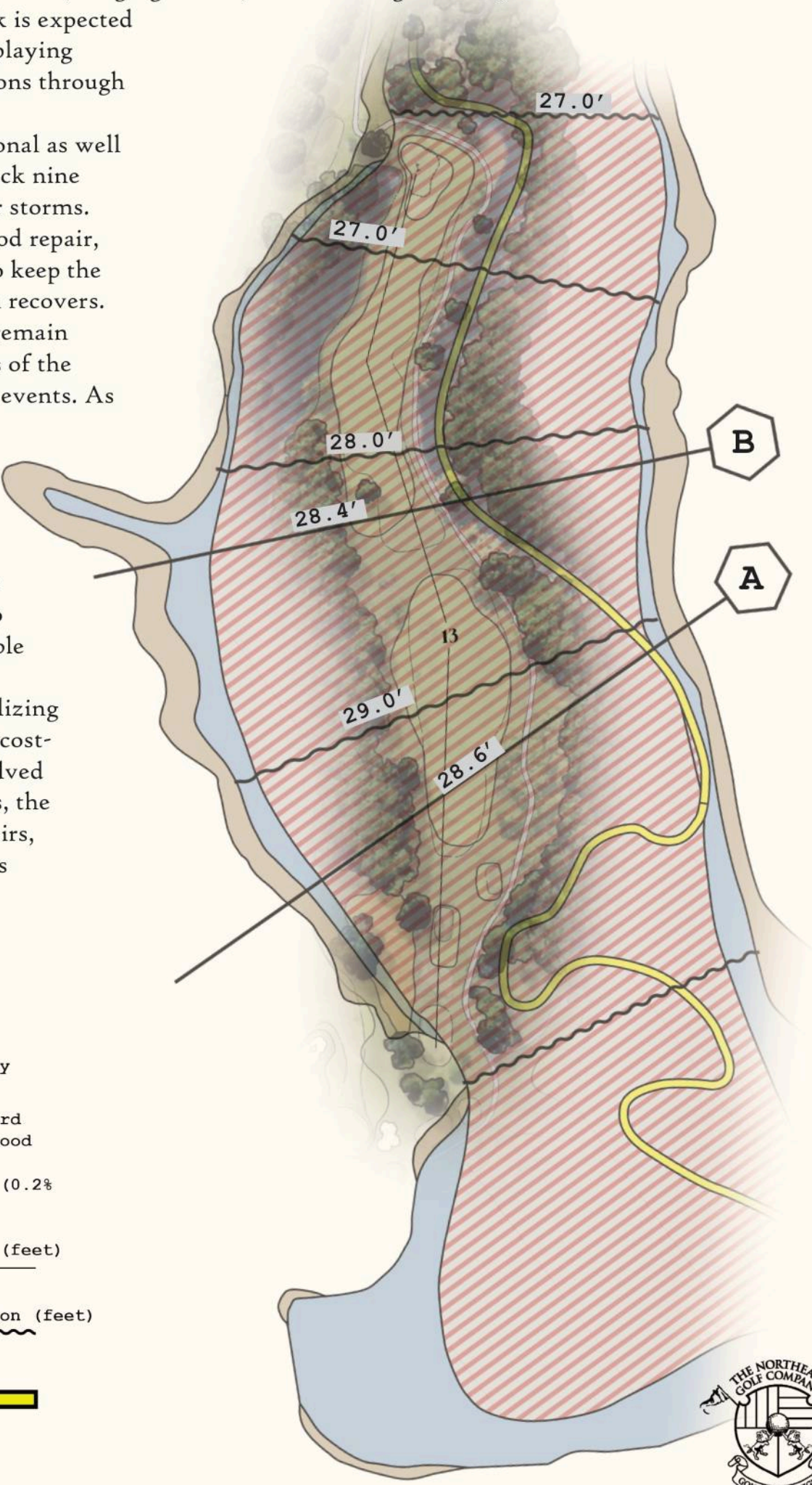
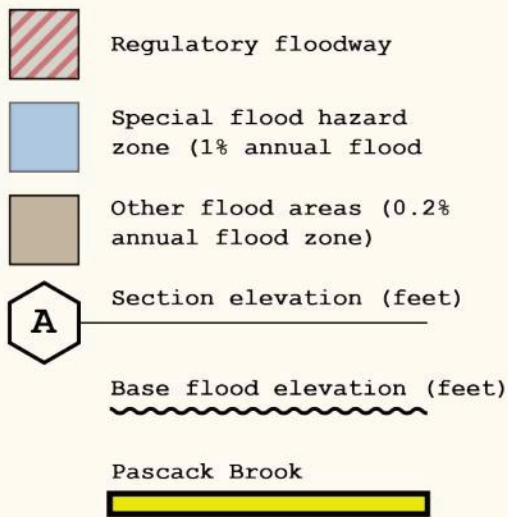
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Hole 13 occupies the lowest ground on the property, running along the western edge of the course where the playing corridor meets Pascack Brook. The hole presents an ongoing challenge from stream flooding and bank erosion. Heavy rainfall overtops the banks of the brook and floods the fairway and green; ongoing erosion along the bank steadily narrows the corridor and threatens the long-term integrity of the hole.

The map at right is the FEMA flood hazard map for the Hole 13 corridor. The red-hatched zone is the regulatory floodway, the channel reserved for the active flow of floodwaters during a major event. The blue zone is the Special Flood Hazard Area, with a one-percent annual chance of flooding (the 100-year floodplain); the tan zone carries a 0.2-percent annual chance (the 500-year floodplain). Together, the three zones cover nearly the entire hole. The base flood elevations marked along the corridor, ranging from 27.0 feet at the green to 29.0 feet near the back of the fairway, are the elevations to which the brook is expected to rise in a 100-year event. Existing playing surfaces sit at or below these elevations through much of the corridor.

The consequences are operational as well as agronomic. Flooding closes the back nine in the immediate aftermath of major storms. Recovery requires intensive post-flood repair, often including a temporary green to keep the hole in play while the primary green recovers. Turf conditions across the corridor remain compromised through long stretches of the playing season, even between major events. As the bank continues to erode, the playable width of the hole narrows year by year.

Two alternatives were evaluated before arriving at the proposed approach. Rerouting or redesigning the surrounding holes to abandon the corridor proved infeasible given wetland restrictions and the property's acreage constraints. Stabilizing the stream bank with sheet piling is cost-prohibitive and would not have resolved the underlying flooding; the closures, the temporary green, the post-flood repairs, and the compromised turf conditions would all have continued.



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HOLE 13

490 • 470 • 420

The proposed work addresses both the flooding and the bank erosion directly, while preserving the hole's existing corridor and strategic character. The plan takes a more targeted and cost-effective path than the alternatives considered, and is designed to be implemented in coordination with Bergen County and the relevant permitting authorities.

Within the hole corridor, the plan raises the fairway and green above flood elevation and introduces low-lying collection areas to manage water during smaller events. Subsurface drainage is installed across the corridor to evacuate residual water from the raised playing surfaces, and a force-main system carries floodwaters from the collection areas to the irrigation pond, where they can be stored and reused rather than allowed to stand on the hole. Erosion is mitigated through strategically placed rip-rap at the stream bend points where scour is most active.

Together, these measures will keep Hole 13 playable through many of the storm events that currently force closure, and will dramatically reduce the time and expense of recovery following extreme weather. The hole's existing corridor, its strategic character, and its visual relationship to Pascack Brook are preserved. The result is a more resilient hole that honors its existing design while performing reliably in conditions that have historically taken it out of play.

NOTES

- A: Remove stumps around back tee.
- B: Remove 10 trees inside and 9 trees outside the cart path at the start of the fairway.
- C: Create low area between the split fairway.
- D: Raise portions of the fairway and install subsurface drainage.
- E: Remove unhealthy trees at the river's edge.
- F: Remove tree at left at 130 yards.
- G: Rip-rap creek at bend points.
- H: Rebuild/raise green complex above flood elevations.
- I: Install force-main system moving floodwaters to irrigation pond.



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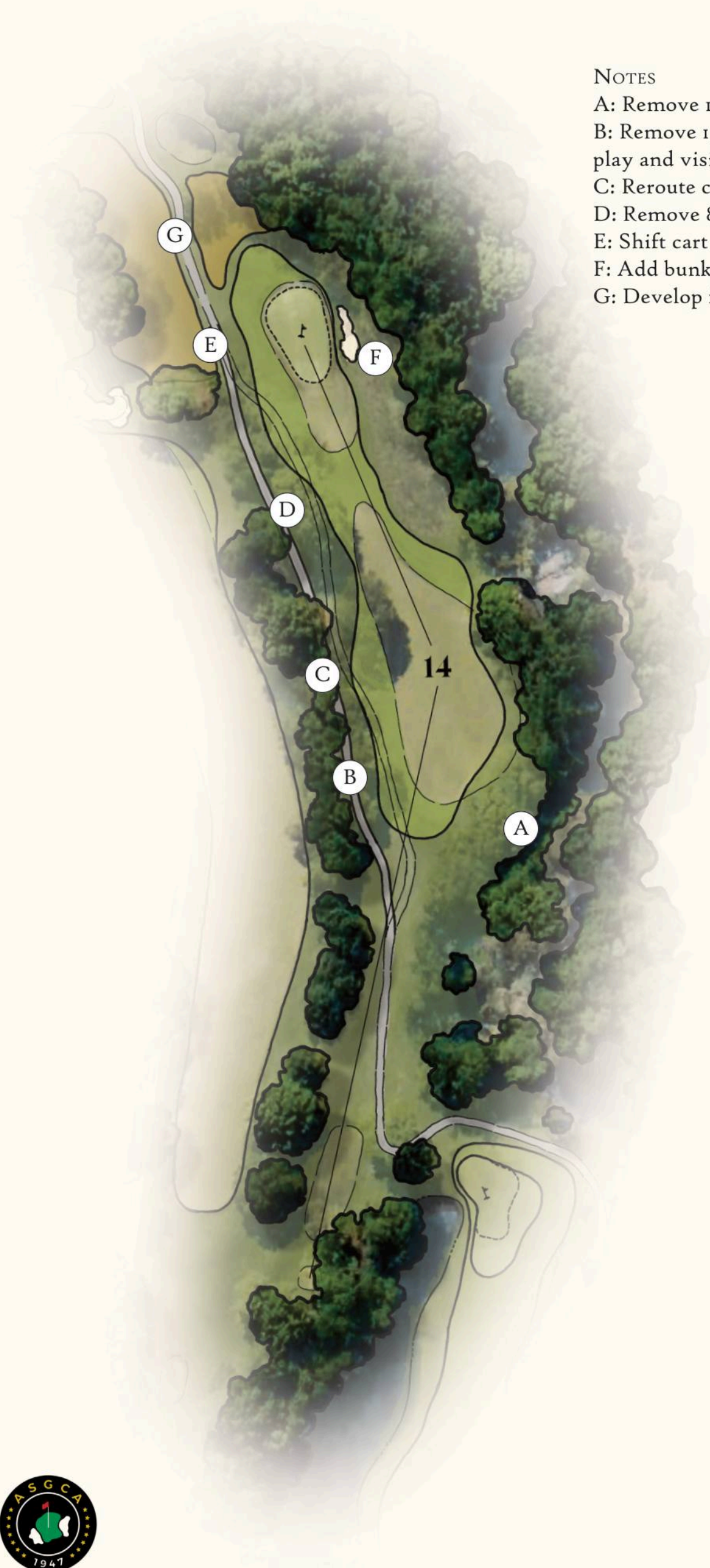
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HOLE 14

335 • 320 • 290

NOTES

- A: Remove 10-14 trees along right side to the creek.
- B: Remove 15-20 trees at left side to open corridor of play and visibility to landing area.
- C: Reroute cart path away from center of the hole.
- D: Remove 8-10 trees at approach to open line of play.
- E: Shift cart path left at green.
- F: Add bunkering.
- G: Develop fescue framing within 14/15 triangle.



not to scale



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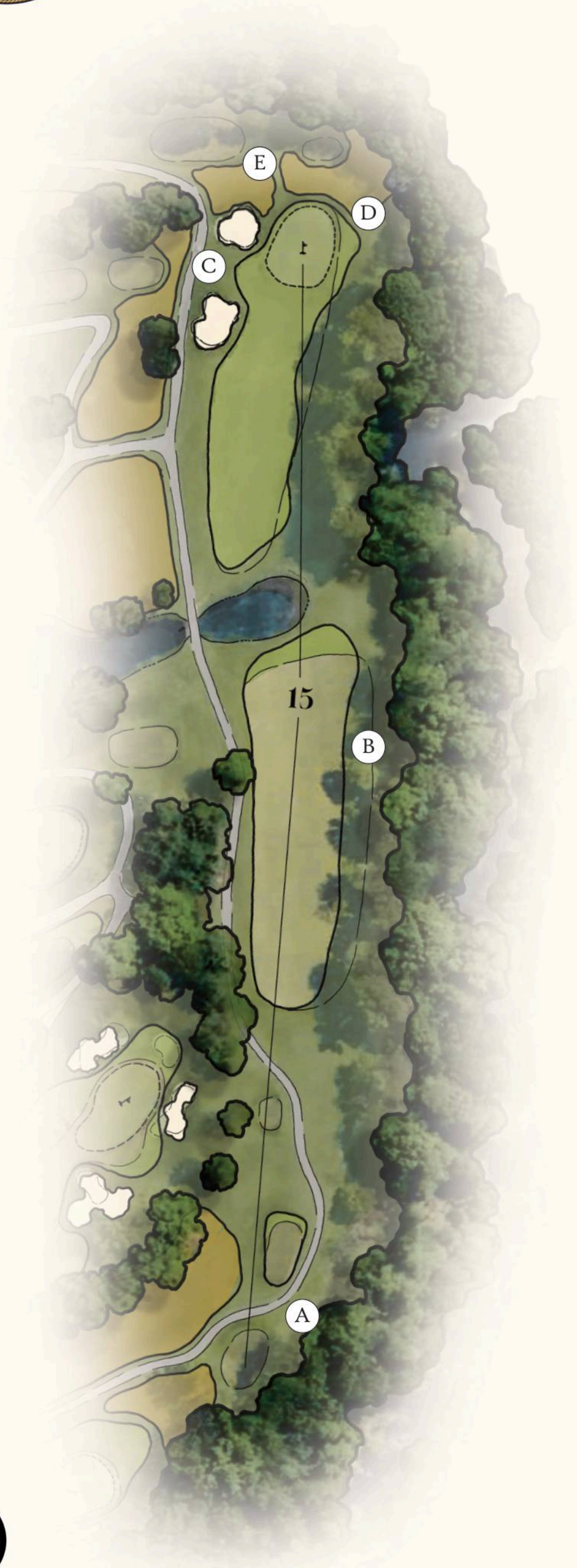


Valley Brook Golf Course

15 Rivervale Rd. River Vale, NJ 07675

HOLE 15

395 • 360 • 305



- NOTES
- A: Strip/level/expand tees.
 - B: Adjust fairway perimeter for better light/airflow. Extend fairway toward pond.
 - C: Rebuild/enhance bunkering.
 - D: Develop pitch areas around green.
 - E: Fescue framing at hillside at left of path and behind green.



not to scale



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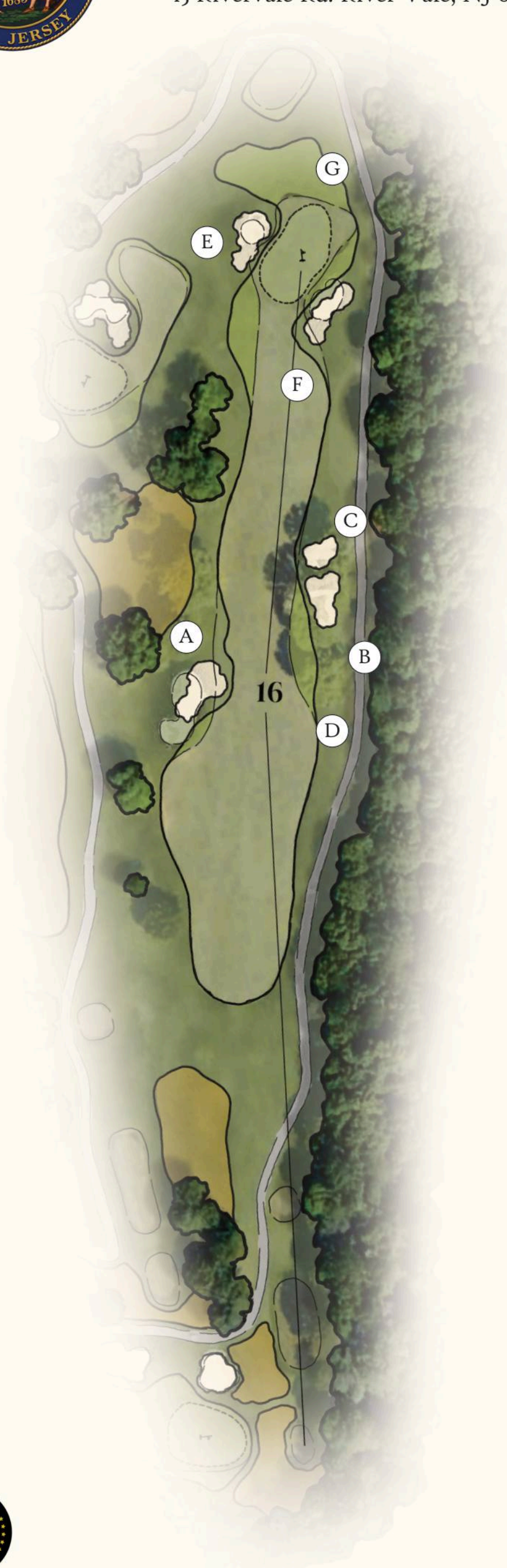


VALLEY BROOK GOLF COURSE

15 Rivervale Rd. River Vale, NJ 07675

HOLE 16

440 • 400 • 350



NOTES

- A: Rebuild/reposition left fairway bunker.
- B: Remove 5 trees inside of cart path, potentially leaving one tree.
- C: Add two new bunkers at right.
- D: Widen fairway at right to run into new bunkers.
- E: Rebuild/enhance greenside bunkers.
- F: Drainage/turf repairs front of right greenside bunker.
- G: New pitch area tied into 17 forward tee.



not to scale



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Valley Brook Golf Course

15 Rivervale Rd. River Vale, NJ 07675

HOLE 17

175 • 160 • 95

- NOTES
- A: New forward tee tied into pitch area behind 16 green.
 - B: Expand/level tees.
 - C: Rebuild greenside bunkers, including shortening back bunker to accommodate expanded pitch area.
 - D: Expand pitch areas left and right of green.
 - E: Tie expanded pitch area at right to 18 tee.



not to scale



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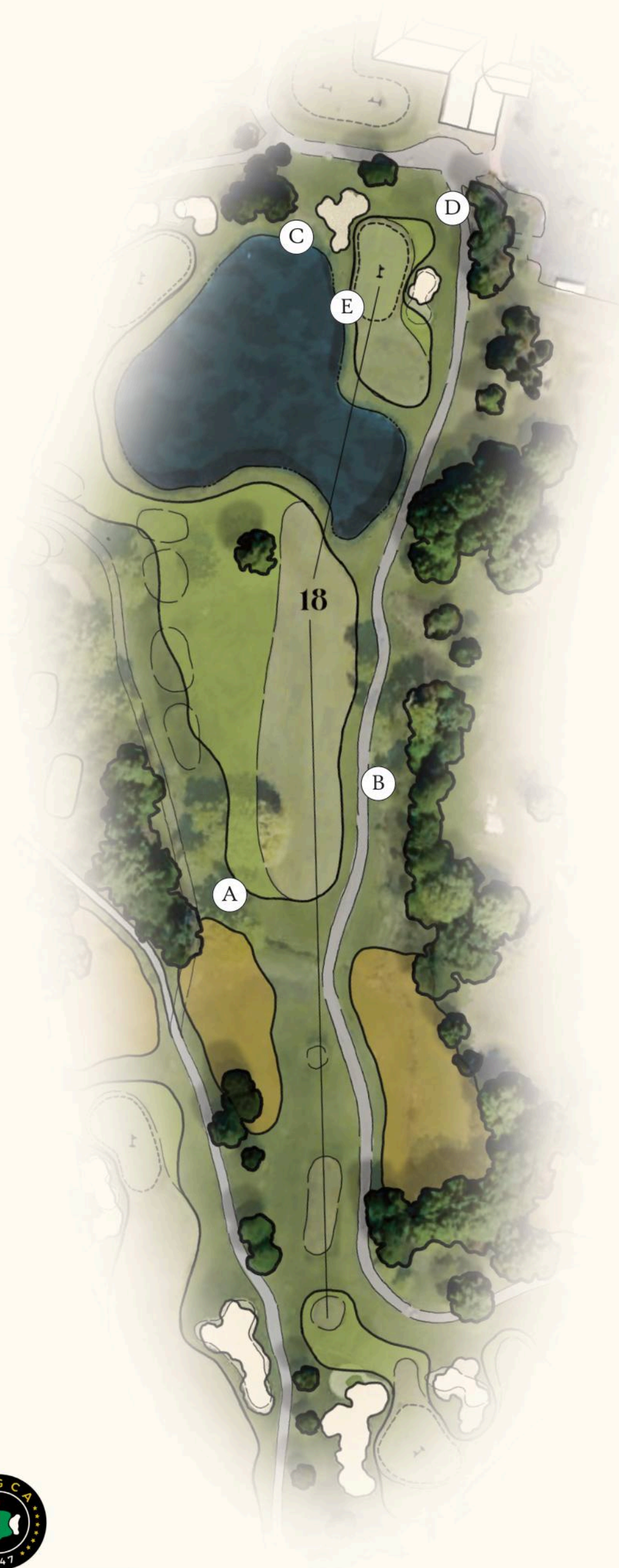


VALLEY BROOK GOLF COURSE

15 Rivervale Rd. River Vale, NJ 07675

HOLE 18

360 • 335 • 285



NOTES

A: Remove 5 trees between 9 and 18 fairway; all except the last tree near the water.

B: Remove trees inside cart path and 2 right of the path.

C: Rebuild/enhance/add greenside bunkers.

D: Create new pitch area at back right of the green.

E: Option: Rebuild green, expand, improve surface and intrigue.



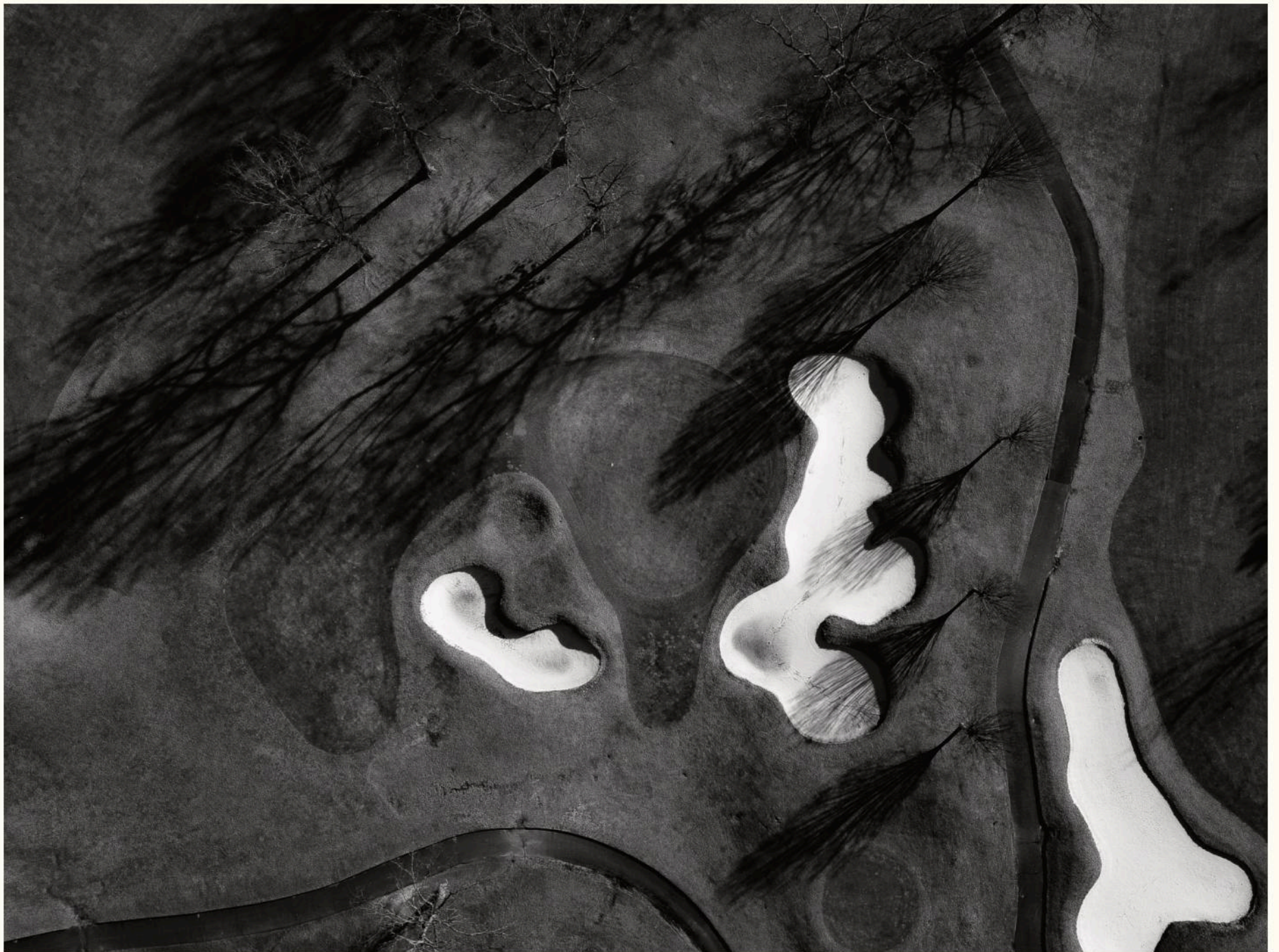
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2026 MASTER PLAN



BERGEN COUNTY OF NEW JERSEY VALLEY BROOK GOLF COURSE

15 Rivervale Rd. River Vale, NJ 07675